

ratio can be seen at state level. The gender ratio varied from 818 in Chandigarh to 1084 in Kerala in 2011. In case of Child Sex Ratio (CSR) Haryana was at the bottom with CSR of 834 while Meghalaya and Mizoram were at the top with CSR of 970. Pondicherry and Kerala have maximum number of women in India while Haryana and Daman & Diu have lowest gender ratio. Few states like Maharashtra, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh showed improvement in gender ratio in 2011.

There has been sharp deterioration in the gender ratio in Bihar from 946 in 1981 to 916 in 2011. In Punjab, U.P and Haryana gender ratio varies from 877 to 908 per 1000 males.

**Table 3.5: Gender Ratio (female per 1000 males) in Major States of India
Arranged in Descending Order on the Basis of 1991, 2001 and 2011 Census**

S. No.	State	1991	2001	2011
1.	Kerala	1040	1058	1084
2.	Tamil Nadu	972	986	995
3.	Andhra Pradesh	972	978	992
4.	Odisha	972	972	978
5.	Himachal Pradesh	996	970	974
6.	Karnataka	960	964	968
7.	West Bengal	917	934	947
8.	Assam	925	932	935
9.	Madhya Pradesh	932	920	930
10.	Rajasthan	913	922	926
11.	Maharashtra	936	922	925
12.	Gujarat	936	921	918
13.	Bihar	912	921	916
14.	Uttar Pradesh	882	898	908
15.	Punjab	888	874	893
16.	Haryana	874	861	877
17.	India	927	933	940

Source: Census of India 2001, Series 1, Paper 1 of 2001, Provisional Population Totals, Census of India 2011, Provisional population, Totals.

3.3.4 Literacy and Gender Composition

Literacy is an important indicator of development. It helps in advancing modernisation, urbanisation, industrialisation, communication, and commerce. It plays a vital role in economic mobility, creating equality and contributing to social development including by addressing the factors behind imbalances in the sex ratio. The spread of education and improvement in educational status has led to the fall in the sex ratio. As per the reports of NFHS-5 (National Family Health Survey, 2019-20) Andhra Pradesh (68.6%), Bihar (57.8%) and Telangana (66.6%)

accounted for lowest literacy rates among women, while Kerala (98.3%), Lakshadweep (96.5%) and Mizoram (94.4%) recorded the highest literacy rate among women in surveyed states and UTs. Literacy according to the survey refers to women or men who completed standard 9 or higher and women or men who can read a whole sentence or part of sentence.

3.3.4.1 Gender Selective Abortions in India

The proportion of female in India's total population has been low and declining since several decades. The declining gender ratio or sex imbalances have been the cause of grave concern since it reflects the mindsets of people. India is a country where son is given strong preference compared to daughters in many families. There are various social, cultural, and economic factors like economic support, property inheritance, old age security, prestige, beliefs about religious rituals and salvation that leads to preference for sons over daughters. The son is seen as an insurance against old age in the absence of strong social security system. The discriminatory allocation of good diet, medical care and other family resources in favour of sons over daughters is due to the consideration of potential benefits that puts sons above daughters. Daughters in many families in India are still considered as financial liability by their parents. A study conducted by CARE (Co-operative for American Relief Everywhere) for pre-school children in Punjab showed that 29 per cent of male children suffered from severe malnutrition but the proportion was 71 per cent in case of females. Consequently, infant mortality rates are high among girl child even in states like Punjab which has the highest per-capita income.

The sudden fall in the number of girls aged 0-6 years age group shows linkages between invention of new medical technologies such as pre-natal diagnostic techniques and increased incidence of sex selective abortions or female foeticide. The advancement in medical technologies has led to misuse of sex determination technologies such as ultrasound scanning and amniocentesis. These technologies were introduced to determine genetic abnormalities among fetus and were used to detect sex of the child.

The recent legislation about Medical Termination of Pregnancy embodied in 1971 Act states that abortion can be performed legally if pregnancy causes danger to the life of the women or if it affects her physical or mental health or if the child is going to be born with serious abnormalities. The proliferation of sex determination tests (amniocentesis) has made it possible to kill female foetus before birth. The unregulated sex determination and female infanticide prior to birth has exercised a negative influence on sex ratio which is moving against the females.

3.3.4.2 Government Response

Sex determination tests have become a part of strategy to ensure desired family sex composition. Sex selection in fact is preferable alternative to female infanticide or discriminatory ill-treatment of girls after birth. The response of Indian government has been slow and ineffective.

In 1998 The Prenatal Diagnostic Techniques Regulations and Prevention of Misuse Bill was introduced. The law covers all the clinics, hospitals and laboratories offering prenatal testing.

The salient features of the bill are as follows-

- 1) Prenatal Diagnostics can only be conducted to detect genetic abnormalities (including sex linked genetic diseases).
- 2) The test may only be undertaken by high-risk pregnant women who meet at least one of the following criteria
 - a) Age over 35 years
 - b) History of 2 or more abortions
 - c) History of exposure to hazardous substances
 - d) Family history of genetic disorder
 - e) Any other conditions as specified by the authorities
- 3) Use of prenatal diagnostic technologies for indicating the sex of the foetus is banned. Offences are punishable by both imprisonment and a fine.

The government sponsored girl child schemes like Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, Sukhanya Samridhi Yojana, Balika Samridhi Yojana, Dhanalakshmi Scheme, C.B.S.E Udaan Scheme have been introduced to bring change in social attitude towards girl children. The government also needs to address the issues like low levels of education, poor health, unhygienic living conditions and poverty to uplift the status of the women in society. With economic development and high female literacy and female labour force participation rate the gender bias against women are bound to decline and the sex ratio will improve.

3.3.5 Age Composition

The age structure or composition of a population is the distribution by age of the population. Age is the central concept in demography for two reasons:

- 1) Demographic behaviour and benefits of demographic dividend depends on the age structure of the population.
- 2) Populations of different age structure relate to each other.

As populations shift from high mortality and high fertility to low mortality and low fertility there will be a bulge in the younger age group. This youth bulge can be a burden or dividend depending upon policies, institutions, and economic circumstances. If the economy hits rock bottom and there is high unemployment youth may turn to criminal activity or generate social unrest. Otherwise, demographic dividend helps in accelerating economic growth.

In the age group 0-14 the male population is about 1 per cent more than the female population. A higher proportion of male and female in the working age group 15-59 live in the urban areas as compared to rural areas. The Table 3.6 shows that a declining child population (0-14) and old age group (60+) reflects a declining dependency ratio in the rural and urban areas. An increasing working age population reflects that India is enjoying the benefits of favourable demographics and potential demographic dividend in near future. This youth bulge can be demographic dividend or demographic disaster depending upon governance, infrastructure, education, health, employment opportunities etc.